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The 1970s

A NEW GLOBAL HISTORY FROM CIVIL RIGHTS TO ECONOMIC INEQUALITY

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Chapter 6

MORE AND LESS EQUAL SINCE THE 1970S

"YOU CAN CALL ME ANYTHING YOU WANT, but do not call me a racist." President George W. Bush was responding to accusations that the failure of the federal government to respond swiftly to the devastation of Hurricane Katrina in 2005 was partially due to the hardest-hit New Orleans residents being primarily poor and working-class African Americans—and likely Democratic voters, to boot. Bush's reply captured a fundamental truth about American public life in the new millennium. No label was more damaging to a public figure than being identified as racist. Even this conservative Texas Republican, whose party since 1964 had been associated with those white voters least sympathetic to black people, wanted nothing to do with it. He meant it. Bush's closest foreign policy adviser—and an intimate family friend—was Condolezza Rice, a black woman. His first secretary of state was Colin Powell, an African American. His sister-in-law, Columba Bush, was from Mexico. No simple good ol' boy from the patriarchal South, Bush was also comfortable with powerful women, including Rice and his influential domestic adviser, Karen Hughes.[1]

In 2008, American voters elected Barack Obama by a solid majority, putting the first African American in the White House. It did not mean that racial discrimination and prejudice had disappeared. It certainly did not mean that black economic disadvantage had ended. But the election did mark a level of white acceptance of blacks in positions of authority that would have seemed nearly unimaginable a generation earlier. Voters were also demonstrating a cultural inclusiveness, choosing this son of a Kenyan father and white American mother, a man who had grown up in Hawaii and Indonesia and who carried an Islamic

middle name—Hussein—that was the very name of the tyrant in Iraq—Saddam Hussein—against whom the United States had just been at war. After the election, Americans of differing political stripes took comfort in the outcome. Obama's supporters were obviously pleased, as was most of the rest of the world. But even conservatives who voted against Obama pointed to the result as evidence of a striking degree of equality in American public life and opportunities. Observers in other countries rued the unlikelihood of electing a member of an ethno-racial minority to the top political office in their nations. Comedy writers for late-night television shows were perhaps less happy, at least professionally, finding little suitable target for satire in the new president. "Anything that has even a whiff of being racist, no one is going to laugh," explained Rob Burnett, an executive producer for the David Letterman show. "The audience is not going to allow anyone to do that."[2]

While American public life grew generally more inclusive and egalitarian after the 1970s, attitudes toward government regulation and taxation continued to slide further into negative territory. "You had an intellectual conviction that you did not need much regulation—that the market could take care of itself," recalled Paul Volcker, the chairman of the Federal Reserve from 1979 to 1987, as he later came to regret his own partial acceptance of that view after the economic crisis of 2008. Reagan's two terms in office and his dominance of the American political landscape in the 1980s elevated market values, while discrediting the role of the federal government as it had developed since the New Deal fifty years earlier. "Government's view of the economy could be summed up in a few short phrases," he explained in 1986. "If it moves, tax it. If it keeps moving, regulate it. And if it stops moving, subsidize it." Reagan's contrarian view of government epitomized mainstream American politics after 1980. This vision helped Republicans under the small-government leadership of Rep. Newt Gingrich of Georgia seize control of the U.S. House of Representatives in 1994 for the first time in four decades. The only non-Republican president elected between 1980 and 2008 was the self-proclaimed "New Demo-

crat" Bill Clinton, "new" for distancing himself from the New Deal tradition, who still wound up spending most of his eight years in the White House (1993–2001) in a defensive posture toward a Republican-dominated Congress. Steep tax cuts in 2001 and 2003 were emblems of the George W. Bush administration's pro-market, anti-regulatory stance. Partisan gridlock in Congress—from the 1995 shutdown of government services to the 1998 impeachment of Clinton, to the nearly lockstep threat of filibuster against Obama's initiatives by the opposition party—contributed to a broadening public perception that government simply does not work well.[3]

"Politics moved right just as the culture moved left." This evaluation of the 1980s by historian Robert Collins holds true for the sweep of American life since the 1970s. Greater inclusiveness and formal equality were accompanied by growing distrust of government and the rise of market values. Over more than three decades, the result was a more diverse public culture in the realm of employment, entertainment, and politics, on the one hand, and a more economically differentiated society, on the other. Class differences widened, as measured by the distribution of income and wealth. But Americans had long been loath to talk about class divisions, something associated for the past century with Marxist analysis. Historian William Appleman Williams referred to this resistance to discussing class as "the Great Evasion" in American life. Rather than addressing growing economic inequality, Americans tended instead to celebrate racial and ethnic diversity. Writer Walter Benn Michaels noted how cultural liberalism and economic conservatism formed a de facto alliance. It had become the contemporary American condition, the ground on which the vaunted American middle class continued to shrink.[4]

Evidence to the Contrary

It took little effort to find evidence of enduring inequality in the United States, based on group identities such as race, ethnicity,

sex, disability, religion, and sexual orientation. For all the formal inclusiveness of public life, the actual private lives of Americans—like peoples anywhere—negotiated daily a wide array of prejudices and discriminatory practices. One saw this in household chores and caring for children: despite significant increases in men's contributions in these areas, women continued to shoulder the vast majority of domestic duties, even as they worked outside the home as much as men and were paid less for it, on average. Single-adult households with children, rising sharply in number, were usually headed by women. One saw this enduring prejudice in the lives of gays and lesbians: despite vast changes in their legal and moral status in American society, they still faced a threat of violence and condemnation unknown to most heterosexuals. One saw this among American Muslims and the hatred they encountered after the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks by al-Qaeda on U.S. targets. And one saw this in the resentment and disrespect that Latinos often encountered from those who associated a Spanish surname or a Latino accent with undocumented immigration.[5]

African Americans remained the citizens most likely to experience direct discrimination on the basis of group identity. This was not surprising. Centuries of race slavery, segregation, and discrimination developed a robust foundation for anti-black prejudice, a reality weakened since the 1960s but not yet eliminated. The cornerstone was stolen labor. While white families built up inheritable wealth over generations, black families were largely prevented by bondage, law, and policy from doing so. In 2003, the median net worth of black households was 10 percent of that of white households. From the initial wellspring of this crucial disadvantage flowed a river of inequality: in health, education, social connections, self-esteem, employment, and opportunity. Prisons became more familiar to young black men, on average, than colleges. Black unemployment rates ran significantly higher than white unemployment rates. The growth of a robust black middle class in the past two generations was real and critically important, but it sometimes masked the enduring reality of poverty and discrimination. African American scholar

Stephen Carter explained that "America has two black communities, really, and one of them is falling further and further behind." Residential segregation by race changed only marginally in the past three decades. It remained profoundly easier to be white—and male—in the United States. Comedian Chris Rock made this point concisely with mainly white audiences: "None of you would trade places with me, and I'm rich!"[6]

Racial dislike and even hatred lingered since the 1970s like a persistent mist shrouding uncertain ground. At times the mist hardened into solid, brutal form, such as the vicious beating by police of unarmed motorist Rodney King in Los Angeles in 1991. After a bystander captured the traumatic scene on videotape, television viewers across the country and the world saw briefly the tense reality of black men's common experience with real or threatened physical force by the authorities. A year later, a jury with no black members acquitted the four officers on the videotape. African American rage at injustice exploded into a ferocious race riot in south-central Los Angeles, where racially targeted murder and mayhem flowed between blacks, whites, Asians, and Latinos. After 1992, racial violence was confined to smaller-scale incidents. In 1998, for example, three white men near Jasper, Texas, dragged an African American acquaintance to death behind a speeding pick-up truck, and in 2006, racial fights in a Louisiana high school divided the small community of Jena. White supremacist organizations continued to persist in places like northern Idaho, reminding African Americans and other Americans of color that some of their fellow citizens wished them only ill. Racial sentiment provided one ingredient in many citizens' opposition to Barack Obama, a fact expressed openly by some. A spike in racially explicit threats of violence against the president followed his election.[7]

Prejudice and discrimination against people of color could be found across the political spectrum, but one of the two major American political parties positioned itself as the voice of those white Americans least sympathetic to the concerns of African Americans. This is not to say that all Republicans were racist—hardly. But it does suggest why George W. Bush was defensive

about accusations of racial neglect in the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina. The party of Abraham Lincoln had chosen since the early 1960s to position itself, above all, as the party of the white South and the white suburbs. Its leaders were often not shy about this strategy. In 1964, Barry Goldwater ran for president on a platform opposing the Civil Rights Act. In 1968, Richard Nixon endorsed a "Southern strategy" of pursuing segregationist voters. In 1980, Ronald Reagan opened his presidential campaign in Philadelphia, Mississippi, declaring his support for "states' rights" in a county known for the infamous murder of three civil rights workers only sixteen years earlier. In 1988, George H. W. Bush won the presidency after using a controversial advertisement linking his opponent to the release from jail of a convicted black murderer who then raped a white woman. In 1990, Jesse Helms won reelection to the Senate from North Carolina with an advertisement appealing explicitly to white resentment of affirmative action policies. In 2002, Senate majority leader Trent Lott of Mississippi publicly praised the 1948 white supremacist presidential candidacy of Strom Thurmond: "When Strom Thurmond ran for president, we [Mississippians] voted for him. We're proud of it. And if the rest of the country had followed our lead, we wouldn't have had all these problems over all these years." Other Republican leaders quickly distanced themselves from Lott's remarks, and he resigned from his leadership role. "But an important reason why both the White House and conservative pundits were so eager to condemn Trent Lott was not because Lott had long been out of touch with the party's values," historian Joseph Crespino wrote, "but because his remark crystallized so succinctly the reactionary populist resentment of the modern civil rights struggle and the important role that that antipathy has played in fueling modern conservative politics."[8]

Crespino and other careful observers noted the direct connection between white racial backlash since the 1960s and the declining status of government and the public sector. Put bluntly, as African Americans and other people of color were increasingly included in a formally egalitarian society, some of their

white countrymen reacted by withdrawing their sympathies and votes from social welfare programs and from governmental operations in general. Historian Kevin Kruse identified this phenomenon in the case of Atlanta since the beginnings of desegregation in the 1950s. Longtime California newspaperman Peter Schrag described this development in the Golden State in the 1970s, where older white voters backed the tax revolt as they disengaged from key publicly funded mandates like the public schools and universities that had growing numbers of nonwhite students. By the early 2000s, various social science studies indicated that up to half of Americans' greater antipathy toward government spending on social services resulted from the nation's racial and ethnic diversity. This diversity undermined white support for collective funding of public goods of all kinds, from parks to food stamps to elementary schools. By contrast, European voters tended to see recipients of such goods as similar to themselves and thus more readily supported such spending. Meanwhile, white citizens in the United States responded to greater diversity in their society by withdrawing a portion of their support for the public sphere.[9]

Just as greater formal equality and inclusiveness in American society since the 1970s did not eliminate racial prejudice or racial gaps in wealth and education, the rise of free-market values did not eradicate Americans' dependence on and even affection for their government and its programs. In fact, as the U.S. population grew 36 percent from 1980 to 2010, the sheer size of federal, state, and local governments expanded as well. Like all bureaucracies, governments aimed above all to perpetuate themselves. It was the nature of large organizations. But governments also provided services, and citizens came to depend on those services much more than they sometimes liked to admit, and sometimes more than they realized. Foremost among the expenses of the U.S. government, besides payment on existing debt, was the vast military force that had bases in every state and on every continent abroad. No other nation since the demise of the Soviet Union approached the level of U.S. spending on military purposes. Indeed, the United States invested more in

"defense" than the next ten largest national militaries *combined*. Yet there was little organized domestic opposition to the scale of this military spending, even after the end of the Cold War. Americans, by and large, seemed to have accepted, and to continue to support, an extraordinary global role for their military forces—that is, for the armed element of their government. Disproportionate military strength seemed to be part of the American identity. It also served as a kind of covert welfare system. Vast government spending on the military provided literally millions of jobs, in military service directly as well as in ancillary services around military bases, in military contracting, and in medical care for veterans. It was not the free market, and it was popular.[10]

The other largest federal outlays paid for domestic services directly affecting the lives of even more Americans. The Social Security system established in 1935 came to define, for most citizens, what their government owed them in retirement. After they retired and their paychecks disappeared, they counted on this federal program to provide for their most basic sustenance. Between 1980 and 2010, pensions disappeared for most American workers, leaving them dependent in retirement on their own savings—including 401(k) plans—and, above all, their Social Security check. The same was true for health-care insurance in retirement. Americans aged sixty-five and over, who typically required more medical care than younger citizens, came to depend on the Medicare system established in 1965. Indeed, their fierce and specific loyalty to Medicare sometimes conflicted head-on with their broad but vaguer support for "less government," lower taxes, and more leeway for the free market. One speaker at a 2009 town-hall meeting in Simpsonville, South Carolina, on health-care reform declared: "Keep your government hands off my Medicare!" Such confusion made sense for a citizenry committed to the benefits of specific government programs while supposedly disenchanted with the public sphere in general.[11]

Three decades of anti-regulatory rhetoric did not eliminate Americans' unthinking assumption that their government should

protect them from harm on a daily basis. They bought meat and medicines in confidence that inspectors from the Food and Drug Administration were assuring their safety. They drove on highways and over bridges without wondering if they would hold up. They drank water from their kitchen taps without thinking if local officials were assuring its potability. They worked in factories in confidence that the Occupational Safety and Health Administration monitored dangerous machinery and materials. They boarded airplanes with the knowledge that pilots passed rigorous training tests and airplane equipment was regularly inspected by the Federal Aviation Administration. They lined up for seasonal flu shots when the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention recommended them. They dialed "911" when they were in trouble and simply assumed police, fire, and emergency personnel would respond immediately. In these and a myriad of other aspects of their daily lives, citizens did not rely—and would never have dreamed of relying—on a truly free market. They expected and demanded government protection. This is what taxes paid for. Taxes were the price of civilization.[12]

The rhetorical dominance of free-market values in American politics since the 1970s, then, masked some older, New Deal-style loyalties. The severe economic recession that began in December 2007 further tested Americans' commitment to a less regulated economy. The steep decline in real estate values, the rise in unemployment above 10 percent, and particularly the collapse and near-collapse of major investment banks shook people's faith in unregulated markets. Even the most ardent defenders of entrepreneurship were shocked. "A system Americans have trusted—the market—has failed in important ways," observed conservative columnist David Brooks. Former Federal Reserve chairman Alan Greenspan, a once revered figure, came under withering criticism, and conceded that "I have found a flaw" in the pro-market ideology that led him to make "a mistake" in trusting banks to protect the interests of their shareholders. "We are learning from [these events] that we need a more active and intelligent government to keep our mode of a capitalist economy from running off the rails," wrote federal

appeals court judge Richard Posner, a leading figure in the conservative Chicago school of economics. "The movement to deregulate the financial industry went too far by exaggerating the resilience—the self-healing powers—of laissez-faire capitalism." Only massive U.S. government intervention, begun by the Republican administration of George W. Bush and continued by the Democratic administration of Barack Obama, kept the damage from growing much worse. The reputation of economist John Maynard Keynes rose sharply in response.[13]

Some observers suggested that the recession that began in late 2007 might mark the end of the deregulatory period since the 1970s. Public opinion and political support may swing back toward a more positive view of government management of the economy, as indicated by Obama's election.[14] Only time will tell. Regardless of whether this proves true, the era from 1980 to 2008 witnessed a full generation of dominant free-market values that reshaped the American political landscape, carrying forward the anti-regulatory logic that seized the high ground in the 1970s. Likewise, the reality of enduring challenges to egalitarianism since 1980 did not derail the dramatic progress of growing inclusiveness in American society. The individualistic emphasis of these twin values of the 1970s defined much of the last thirty years of U.S. history.[15]

Inclusiveness Ascending

American culture was significantly more liberal and open in 2010 than it had been in 1980. This was visible from matters of music, movies, performance arts, and freedom of expression to issues of gender, race, and sexuality. Women's breakthroughs in the 1970s continued to reshape American life most dramatically of all. From a small minority of the paid workforce, women came to hold half the nation's jobs. Women's average paychecks lagged behind men's, but they were catching up. In 1970, 4 percent of husbands had wives who made more money than they did; in 2007, 22 percent did. Women moved up into positions

of authority in the workplace in these years, from schools and hospitals to businesses and governments. They held 51 percent of professional and managerial positions in the U.S. economy in 2010. Ursula Burns became the first black woman to head a top 100 company when she took over as CEO of Xerox Corporation in 2009, succeeding another woman in the position, Anne Mulcahy. Americans in these years became accustomed for the first time to female authority over both women and men as a normal public phenomenon, a transition of vast historical significance.[16]

At the top echelons of political power, women became increasingly visible. Hillary Clinton narrowly missed the Democratic presidential nomination in 2008, while Sarah Palin won the Republican vice presidential nomination. Women as governors became standard fare, including the 1986 gubernatorial race in Nebraska that featured female candidates from both major parties. The number of women in the 535-member U.S. Congress rose from eleven to seventeen during the 1970s, and then leapt to ninety-one in 2009—still less than 20 percent, but increasing steadily. In 2007, Nancy Pelosi (D-CA) became the first female Speaker of the U.S. House of Representatives. The number of women elected to statewide executive offices went from 7 percent to 11 percent during the 1970s, and then zoomed to 25 percent by 2004. Sandra Day O'Connor's elevation to the U.S. Supreme Court in 1981 was followed by Ruth Bader Ginsburg in 1993, Sonia Sotomayor in 2009, and Elena Kagan in 2010. In the deeply symbolic U.S. military, the number of women rose steadily since the 1970s, including in the officer corps. The Persian Gulf War of 1991 marked a turning point, with women becoming more visibly identified as warriors by the public and popular culture. Despite an official ban on women serving in combat positions, they informally began doing precisely that in the unpredictable combat landscapes of Iraq and Afghanistan in the 2000s. They were "attached" rather than "assigned" to combat units, and they piloted aircraft into combat zones. Some also died there.[17]

Sex desegregation and the empowerment of women's public

lives began in schools. In 1970, women earned 43 percent of bachelor's degrees awarded; in 2001, they earned 57 percent. In 1970, women received 6 percent of professional degrees; in 2004, they received almost half. In 2002, Yale Law School enrolled its first class with a majority of women. The following year, Harvard Medical School did the same. Indeed, the success of female applicants to undergraduate institutions began to give them a slight competitive disadvantage, as male applicants benefited from colleges' efforts to preserve a roughly gender-balanced student body. Women's sweeping success in education penetrated the most elite circles. By 2007, half of the eight Ivy League universities had female presidents.[18]

In their personal lives, the struggle for women's equality pressed forward after the 1970s. Female athleticism boomed. During the 1971–72 school year, girls comprised just 7 percent of all participants in high school sports; in 2006–2007, they totaled 41 percent. Women's running took off. From 1971, when three women completed the second New York City Marathon, the number of female finishers soared to 11,715 in 2003. Roughly a third of the racers in New York for the annual event were now women. Pat Summitt built an extraordinarily successful women's basketball program at the University of Tennessee from scratch, bringing in an average of 14,000 fans for each home game in 2008–2009. The U.S. women's national soccer team won the Women's World Cup in 1999, attracting unprecedented public attention to the sport. Downhill skier Lyndsey Vonn's three consecutive World Cup overall titles in 2008–2010 and gold medal at the 2010 Vancouver Winter Olympics embodied the respect, media attention, and money that women athletes earned. One seventy-five-year-old fan of the 2008 national champion University of Nebraska women's volleyball team tried to explain to a reporter the power of a favorite photograph of her team celebrating together. "Every time I look or talk about that photo, I just weep. We were denied so much for so long." As a high school basketball player herself six decades earlier, Lynn Darling and her own teammates had different rules in gym class and were not allowed to run in basketball. "They

wanted us to protect the uterus." Darling wiped her eyes. "It's true. Procreating. That was our purpose." Such a perspective seemed difficult to imagine for contemporary American women. Being female in the United States now meant a different relationship with one's body and different expectations.[19]

Providing equal protection to women also involved, in some cases, recognition of their distinctiveness from men. Most notable was their common status as primary targets of unwanted sexual advances and sexual assault. In 1986, for the first time, the U.S. Supreme Court established a workplace right to be free from "sexual harassment," a new term in American law. In *Meritor Savings Bank v. Vinson*, the Court ruled that unwanted sexual advances in the workplace constituted a form of sex discrimination against women and were thus illegal. Women had the right to be free of a hostile employment environment. This watershed decision eliminated the legal basis for the age-old attitude of "boys will be boys" and the double standard it allowed for appropriate behavior of men toward women, at least in the workplace. The new standard of freedom from sexual harassment—and the struggles that accompanied it—followed women into new employment situations, including the military services.[20]

Even those opposed to parts of the empowerment of women since the 1970s tended to frame their arguments in terms of individual rights. Anti-abortion activists, male and female, focused less on the obligations of motherhood and sexual responsibility, and more on the rights of the fetus as an "unborn child." The campaign to restrict access to abortion services centered on defending the fetus as an elemental matter of protecting human rights. This campaign did not (at least yet) succeed in overturning *Roe v. Wade*'s legalization of abortion, but it did manage to win new restrictions on the practice by individual states, most notably in the Supreme Court's decision in *Planned Parenthood of Southeastern Pennsylvania v. Casey* (1992). These activists called themselves "pro-life," to the dismay of observers who noted their strong tendencies to support capital punishment and to oppose government-provided child social services. "Pro-life" organizers seemed to some to care more about people before they were born than after they were born. But anti-abortion activists were resolute in their commitment to stopping what they saw as the taking of helpless individual human lives, and they succeeded in reducing the availability of abortion services.[21]

At the broadest level, women's position in all aspects of society—economic, political, social, cultural—across the industrialized world became much more equal to men's after the 1960s. Feminism helped shape the two predominant developments that drove this change. One was the rising tide of women entering the paid workforce as economies shifted from industry to information and services. With higher incomes, women were more independent; marriage declined in importance and divorce became more common. The second development was the ready availability of effective contraception, particularly the birth control pill. Women in industrialized countries now controlled their own reproduction and thus their lives to a greater extent than ever before in history. These factors liberated women as individuals, but altered traditional family structures and corroded traditional forms of authority that had held together families, neighborhoods, and even nations. By 2007, for the first time, the majority of adult American women lived without a spouse, either unmarried, separated, divorced, or widowed.[22]

A similar story of increasing public prominence unfolded for African Americans, male and female, after the 1970s. Nonblack Americans grew thoroughly accustomed to black successes in politics, business, education, the arts, sports, and entertainment. After the initial breakthroughs of the 1960s, African Americans became commonplace in positions of executive authority, particularly as mayors of large cities. In 2009, even the mostly white town of Philadelphia, Mississippi, renowned for its brutal hostility toward the civil rights movement in the 1960s, elected its first black mayor, James A. Young. At the state level, in 1989 Virginia's large white-majority citizenry made Douglas Wilder the first elected black governor in the nation. He was followed by Deval Patrick in Massachusetts and David Paterson in New York. Black officials

rapidly lost their novelty at all levels of government. Their very normality helped set the stage for Obama's election to the presidency in 2008.

So did African American prominence in the cultural spheres of music, sports, literature, dance, and film. Nonblack Americans grew very much accustomed to listening to black musicians; they cheered for black athletes, including those in traditionally white leadership positions such as quarterback in football, and black coaches; they listened to television personalities like Oprah Winfrey; and they flocked to theaters to watch movie stars such as James Earl Jones and Denzel Washington. In a culture deeply influenced by Hollywood's images, Americans found nothing odd about Morgan Freeman playing the U.S. president in *Deep Impact* (1998). The mainstreaming of blacks in American public life changed advertising, which began to target black audiences and to use African American images. In the 2000s, the iconic figure of Betty Crocker on mashed-potato box covers was regenerated by computer to be darker and more ethnic-looking than the white, blue-eyed original of 1936. By the 2000s, mainstream television ads even casually included images of black men in the company of white women, a scene scarcely imaginable a few decades earlier. Marriage between members of different races, perhaps the most sensitive indicator of changing racial practices, increased fivefold between 1960 and 2000 and accounted for 8 percent of all marriages in the United States in 2010.[23]

Rising non-European immigration changed the public face of the United States as much as any other factor after the 1970s. Latinos—mostly but not exclusively from Mexico—became the largest racial or ethnic minority in the early 2000s. While anti-immigrant sentiment remained a serious force in American politics, Latinos' prominence as voters gained them newfound respect. Sonia Sotomayor was the first Latina or Latino elevated to the Supreme Court, and even those Republicans opposing her nomination in 2009 trod very carefully to avoid appearing in any way anti-Latino. Thirty Latinos served in Congress in 2010. In the high-tech world of Silicon Valley south of San Francisco,

half the engineers by 2009 had been born overseas, particularly in China, India, and Russia. At the University of California at Berkeley, the nation's most prestigious public university, 46 percent of freshmen in 2006 were Asian American. The 2008 election brought two new ethnic breakthroughs in the U.S. House of Representatives: Steve Austria (R-OH), the first Filipino American, and Anh (Joseph) Cao (R-LA), the first Vietnamese American. Demographers estimated that 2010 was the first year in which the number of babies born to minorities outnumbered that of babies born to whites. In sheer numbers, the nation's future was destined for greater diversity.[24]

One of the most revealing statistics of the success of a minority group in American public life involved religion and the Supreme Court. In 2010, the retirement of John Paul Stevens left the Court without a single Justice who was a Protestant. The Founding Fathers would have been dumbfounded. Three Justices were Jewish: Ruth Bader Ginsburg, Stephen Breyer, and Elena Kagan. The remaining six were Roman Catholic, all appointed after 1985. In a nation with a long history of anti-Jewish and anti-Catholic discrimination, a land where Protestants still remained the large majority, this was a striking development. After the September 11 attacks of 2001, Muslims faced ongoing prejudicial treatment, as did non-European immigrants, but the entirely non-Protestant makeup of the nation's highest court suggested a much more inclusive view of minorities in American life than ever before.[25]

Gays and lesbians made the longest strides the fastest. In the early 1980s, they were still the most marginalized group in the United States, their legitimacy undercut by their absence from most anti-discrimination statutes and the disdain and violence they often encountered. Most homosexuals remained "in the closet," calculating accurately if sadly that keeping their sexual orientation private was safer for their economic, social, and physical well-being. The Supreme Court as late as 1986, in the case of *Bowers v. Hardwick*, declared that states could continue to outlaw private consensual sex between homosexual adults. Indeed, the swing vote in that decision, Justice Lewis Powell,

told one of his clerks that he had never met a gay person. It turned out that the clerk was gay.[26]

The Court was slow to recognize rapid change coming on this issue. Through the 1990s, Americans learned that millions of their family members and friends were gay and mostly just got used to it. *Fortune* magazine in 1991 declared that "homosexuality, once a career-destroying secret, is coming out of the closet in corporate America." In 2000, Vermont passed the first state civil-union law to grant legal recognition to homosexual couples. The Supreme Court reversed itself in 2003 in *Lawrence v. Texas*, finding a right to privacy for consenting adult homosexuals. In 2009, Houston became the first of the nation's largest cities—in conservative Texas, to boot—to elect a gay mayor, Annise Parker. By 2010, five states and Washington, DC, had legalized same-sex marriage, as had ten other nations, including such traditionally Roman Catholic countries as Spain, Portugal, and Argentina. For the first time in its polling, Gallup found that a majority of Americans no longer considered gay and lesbian relationships to be immoral.[27]

The trajectory of public opinion about homosexuality was changing. By the early 2000s, younger Americans considered it much less of an issue than did their elders, and they supported the right to same-sex marriage by a large margin. This pointed to a future in which gays and lesbians were likely to become increasingly accepted as normal Americans. Even prominent conservatives and leaders of traditional institutions found their views on private adult sexual behavior changing. Republican Vice President Richard Cheney had an openly lesbian daughter. Right-wing organizer Phyllis Schlafly had a gay son. Republican senator and 2008 presidential nominee John McCain opposed having openly gay people serve in the U.S. military, but his wife and daughter became public proponents of the right to same-sex marriage. Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Admiral Mike Mullen, the nation's top uniformed officer, explained to Congress in 2010 the growing support in the Pentagon for eliminating the "Don't ask, don't tell" policy, which allowed homosexuals to serve in the military only so long as they kept their sexual orientation private. "It is my personal and professional

belief that allowing homosexuals to serve openly would be the right thing to do. No matter how I look at the issue, I cannot escape being troubled by the fact that we have in place a policy which forces young men and women to lie about who they are in order to defend their fellow citizens." Mullen noted that he had "served with homosexuals since 1968" and that his views had evolved "cumulatively" and "personally" ever since. This was the case with most Americans.[28]

The story of greater formal equality and inclusiveness in public life was not unique to the United States in the decades after the 1970s. It was a global tale. It was also not simple and straightforward in its progression; the world was far too large and diverse for all societies to move in unison with each other. There were, for example, plenty of cases of ethnic hatred and violence, such as—just in the 1990s—the unraveling of the former nation of Yugoslavia, Hindu-Muslim riots in India, and the Hutu genocide of Tutsis in Rwanda. Nonetheless, while racism and xenophobia still stalked the contemporary world, it was true that their expression continued to lose acceptability. Australia renounced its informal "White Australia" policy and began to make a place for itself in Asian affairs and to accept Asian immigrants. White settler states New Zealand, Canada, Australia, and the United States all developed more respectful relationships with their indigenous populations of Maori, First Peoples, Aborigines, and Native Americans, respectively. Namibia threw off its colonial overlord, apartheid-era South Africa. And South Africa itself gave up apartheid in 1990, elected Nelson Mandela president in 1994, and became a model to the world—not a perfect model, but a model—of a relatively peaceful transition from racial authoritarianism to inclusive democracy.

Markets Persisting

The new multiculturalism visible from the 1970s on was closely connected to globalization. Information and people moved more often and more rapidly, linking cultures and nations more closely together than ever before. Immigration to the United

States rose sharply in the 1980s, 1990s, and 2000s. Computers, satellites, cell phones, cable television, and the Internet accelerated the pace and intensity of connection. The average real cost of air travel plummeted 60 percent between 1969 and 2009. English became the de facto second language almost everywhere. International telephone traffic tripled in volume during the 1990s, and then nearly doubled again by 2002. World trade as a percentage of world economic output tripled between 1945 and 1998. From 10 percent of the U.S. economy in 1979, imports grew to 17 percent in 2007. Across the globe, markets won out. Socialism retreated from Russia, Eastern Europe, China, and Vietnam, holding on only in the poorest backwaters of North Korea and Cuba. The growth of international trade and globalization surprised even the savviest of observers. Henry Kissinger had told the Chinese in 1972, when first negotiating the new Sino-American relationship: "The maximum amount of bilateral trade possible between us, even if we make great efforts, is infinitesimal in terms of our total economy." By 2009, it soared to $409 billion, and China was the second largest trading partner of the United States.[29]

The expansion of information-driven international markets brought rapid, even disorienting change to the economic landscape. The largest American corporations had long been a stable group, the top one hundred taking an average of thirty years to replace half their members during the period from 1917 to 1976, but from 1977 to 1998, it now took just twelve years. In 2007, for the first time ever, the iconic U.S. automobile companies that had so long dominated U.S. and world markets—General Motors, Ford, and Chrysler—sold fewer than half the vehicles bought by American consumers. Geographical distances no longer made the same sense. Telephone numbers halfway across the globe in the U.S.-occupied Green Zone of Baghdad received local American area codes, 703 (metropolitan Washington, including the Pentagon) and 914 (Westchester County, New York). Meanwhile, the labels of intensely familiar products like Coca-Cola shed any indication of an actual place (such as Atlanta, its historic headquarters), carrying instead just the virtual location of an 800 telephone number or a website. Union membership plunged from 29 percent of the U.S. workforce in 1973 to 12 percent in 2009, taking down health insurance and pension benefits for American workers and returning labor relations demographics to the pre–New Deal era.[30]

Disadvantages for workers were balanced, in the eyes of consumer-oriented Americans, by the benefits of the globalized marketplace and an increasingly deregulated economy. The continued spread of gambling epitomized the post-1970s emphasis on freedom for consumers. While at the end of the 1970s gamblers still had to travel to Nevada or Atlantic City to bet legally at a casino, by 2009 they could gamble in some form in forty-two states and in often-elegant Indian casinos in twenty-nine states. Government-owned slot machines tempted young soldiers on U.S. military bases around the globe.[31]

Restrictions on alcohol sales had been similarly loosened. Other than the creation of a national standard minimum age of twenty-one, buying liquor was much easier than it used to be. State lawmakers, in pursuit of new tax revenues and eager to please citizen-consumers, pared back traditional "blue laws" restricting alcohol sales. Bible-belt states like North Carolina gave up "brown-bagging" in restaurants for the profits of selling "liquor by the drink." In 2009, Mormon-dominated Utah eliminated its byzantine system of requiring bars to be member-only clubs, and Colorado joined the now large majority of states with open liquor stores on Sundays. Governments continued their retreat from many salients of their former role as moral policeman.[32]

The Republican Party became the most powerful promoter of freeing up consumers and markets. From 1980 to 2008, the GOP dominated national politics and helped force the Democratic Party also to the right. On no issue was this clearer than lowering taxes. With considerable Democratic support, Republicans led the campaign that successfully cut the top federal income tax rate in half, from 70 percent in 1980 to 35 percent in 2003. The maximum rate for federal capital gains taxes fell even more steeply, from 40 percent in 1978 to 16 percent in 2003.

The key reductions came under Republican president Ronald Reagan in 1981 and 1986 and Republican president George W. Bush in 2001 and 2003. More money stayed in citizens' pockets, particularly in those of the wealthiest Americans. Citizens affected by the top federal income tax bracket were a thin slice of the American population, the same elite who reaped the benefit of lower taxes on capital gains. It was a great era in which to be wealthy.[33]

Both parties joined in weakening government regulation of financial institutions. The Garn-St. Germain Depository Institutions Act of 1982 removed constraints on one formerly staid sector of the banking world, helping usher in the newly risky lending practices of savings-and-loans in the late 1980s, whose defaults wound up costing taxpayers $130 billion. Americans' debt levels climbed and their savings sagged. The 1999 repeal of parts of the Glass-Steagall Act allowed bank holding companies to own other financial companies, removing the wall between old-fashioned, conservative deposit banking and much higher-risk investment banking, and helping lead to the economic meltdown of 2008. President Bush tried but failed to push this logic even further by privatizing the Social Security system in the early 2000s.[34]

The Supreme Court came to share this more skeptical view of government regulation of corporate behavior. In *Citizens United v. Federal Election Commission* (2010), the Court ruled unconstitutional any restrictions on corporate spending in political campaigns, reversing decades of precedents. The largest companies now had to be treated just the same as individual citizens in the realm of political speech. "While American democracy is imperfect," Justice Stevens wrote in dissent, "few outside the majority of this court would have thought its flaws included a dearth of corporate money in politics." But the Court reflected its times. "With their pro-business jurisprudence, the justices may be capturing an emerging spirit of agreement among liberal and conservative elites about the value of free markets," wrote careful observer Jeffrey Rosen in the *New York Times*. "Many Democrats and Republicans, whatever their other disagreements, have come to share a relatively laissez-faire, technocratic vision of the economy and are suspicious of excessive regulations and reflexive efforts to vilify big business."[35]

The bandwagon of disdaining government and promoting privatization of the public sphere reached even to that most central purpose of the state: self-defense. The famous remark of the entrepreneurial character Milo Minderbinder in the satirical hit book and film *Catch-22* (1970) was intended to be absurd: "Frankly, I'd like to see the government get out of the business of war altogether and leave the whole field to private industry." But this increasingly described what actually happened in the U.S. military system by the time of the invasion of Iraq in 2003. Blackwater and other private security firms reaped enormous contracts for providing services that the U.S. military had formerly taken care of on its own. The privatization movement also swept into prison management as private companies began contracting with local governments to operate jails. And the same logic began winning out in transportation systems as well. By the early 2000s, intense freeway traffic congestion convinced half of the states to allow local transportation authorities to operate special, pay-as-you-go lanes or to let the private sector build and run separate roads.[36]

Unrestrained Consumption

The twin beliefs that commerce was the most natural relationship between people, and that consumption was the most natural activity of individuals, came to dominate American life after the 1970s. Advertising linked commerce and consumption, and advertising spread pervasively in these decades. Yankelovich, a market research firm, estimated that a person living in a city in 2007 saw five thousand advertising messages a day, up from two thousand thirty years earlier. Advertisements showed up in places previously free from them—on the windows of public buses, before movies in theaters—and came on the television at louder volume than regular programming. Sports venues like

college football bowl games, once revered for simple names linked to their geography (Cotton Bowl, Orange Bowl, Sugar Bowl), became advertisements: the Chik-Fil-A Bowl in Atlanta, the Tostitos Fiesta Bowl in Phoenix, and the Outback Steakhouse Gator Bowl in Jacksonville. And sports, from college basketball's "March Madness" to the National Football League, became bigger and bigger business. In the case of the Super Bowl, the advertisements sometimes became more the entertainment than the game itself.[37]

Higher education of the nation's youth reflected the now more visibly dominant ethic of consumerism. In 2010, 22 percent of college undergraduates were majoring in business, by far the most popular major on campus. The numbers majoring in the liberal arts and humanities, meanwhile, declined steadily. English majors dropped by half from 1971 to 2001. The number of MBA degrees increased more than fivefold in the same period. Some of this educational shift toward business reflected economic uncertainties and the need to pay off rising student debt. In 1979, the total yearly costs at a four-year public college or university averaged less than $3,000, of which the maximum federal Pell grant covered three-quarters; thirty years later, the average was $14,000, with a full Pell grant covering just one-third of it. But the shift to business reached beyond just economic need. There was a broader change in the values that college students expressed. UCLA students, for example, went from considering "becoming an educated person" or "developing a philosophy of life" to be their primary reason for attending college in the early 1970s to instead "making a lot of money" by the 1990s. Statistics from the U.S. Census Bureau tracked the same story nationally among college freshmen. In 1970, 79 percent said their major goal was to develop a meaningful philosophy of life; in 2005, 75 percent said it was to be financially very well off.[38]

The idea of unrestrained individual consumption seeped into the fabric of American society, most immediately in citizens' diets. From the late 1970s to the early 2000s, the percentage of Americans who were obese more than doubled. In 2010, fully

two-thirds of Americans were either overweight or obese, half in each category. The average American male was seventeen pounds heavier in 2009 than in the late 1970s, and the average female, nineteen pounds heavier. This public health epidemic had many causes. New technologies involving corn syrup and palm oil made soft drinks and high-fat snacks cheaper, more accessible, and higher in calories. Soda swept past milk in popularity. Pizza's soaring sales tripled cheese consumption. Two-job families ate out more frequently, doubling the average fraction of calories from restaurant food, with its higher calories and fat and salt content. Americans ate take-out meals on average 125 times a year in 2008, up from 72 a generation earlier. And Americans smoked cigarettes less, a serious public health advance, but also one that removed a traditional substitute for eating. They also consumed larger portions. The standard-size bottle of Coke grew from 8 to 20 ounces; bagels and muffins bulked up; and fast-food burgers more than doubled in size. In 2004, one critic's response to the introduction by Hardee's of the 1,418-calorie Monster Thickburger, with 107 grams of fat, was: "Would you like a defibrillator with that?" The bottom line was that citizens, including children, ate more and exercised less, as an explosion of new entertainment options kept them indoors and seated in front of computer and television screens. Even their pets grew overweight, a result of more food and less exercise.[39]

Americans had grown more overweight than peoples of other industrialized nations, a change encouraged by American culture. Indeed, immigrants who came to the United States from elsewhere were rarely obese, but time on American shores tended to change that. After a decade in the United States, the foreign-born lost any earlier advantage. "Trends in obesity among immigrants may reflect acculturation and adoption of the U.S. lifestyle, such as increased sedentary behavior and poor dietary patterns," one prominent group of public health researchers observed. American culture also spread its influence abroad, and other nations were not immune to the same confluence of abundant fast food and proliferating indoor technological diversions. From France to China, from Sweden to Maurita-

nia, from Egypt to Brazil, from Germany to Japan, average weights crept upward, a worrisome indicator of an increasingly global culture of personal consumption.[40]

The pursuit of self-satisfaction with food extended as well to sexuality. In traditional Catholic language, these were the temptations of gluttony and lust. In the contemporary United States, they became just part of the normal landscape of daily life. The loosening private sexual mores of the 1960s and 1970s pervaded public life as well. In the 1980s, Calvin Klein billboards marketed sex with models wearing only jeans. The line of acceptable public nudity and sexual behavior moved dramatically, making "PG" films look like "R" movies of a generation earlier. Openly sexual behavior became commonplace on television, including a vast new empire of on-demand and pay-per-view video, a third of which was sexually explicit programming. In 2007, sex entertainment industry producers began planning for on-demand live sex programming for hotel televisions. Erotic imagery pervaded mainstream American life.[41]

While the growth of pornography represented one end of a wide spectrum of changing sexual mores, at the center was a transformation of marriage and the family. After the 1970s the relationship between sex, marriage, and children was no longer straightforward. Dependable birth control meant that children were no longer an inevitable factor in marriage. The percentage of American babies born to single mothers doubled from 16 percent in 1978 to 32 percent in 1995. Divorce was now commonplace. The public increasingly accepted homosexuality as an option. The average age of Americans getting married increased by several years, as young women and men waited—but they did not necessarily wait to have sexual relationships. The net effect of such changes was that sex outside marriage became not just common, but widely accepted as normal rather than immoral.[42]

Many citizens were troubled by this development but unsure what, if anything, could be done about it. They elected supposedly conservative Republican leaders, several of whom, particularly in the early 2000s, became involved in public sex scandals

of their own—among them Senator Larry Craig (ID), Senator David Vitter (LA), Representative Mark Foley (FL), Governor Mark Sanford (SC), and others. They were pleased by the nomination of the stridently conservative Clarence Thomas to the Supreme Court in 1991, only to learn of his habit of watching pornographic films and to be troubled by serious questions about his treatment of at least one female subordinate. They lobbied against sex education in schools, but some activists wound up introducing into public discourse precisely the kind of explicit, sexually charged language they deplored. The most notable example was the publication of extremely detailed and graphic impeachment charges against President Clinton for an affair with a White House intern. Even when trying to downplay sexuality, Americans seemed to wallow in it.[43]

The new indulgence of the market ethos included not only the realms of gluttony and lust, but also what the traditional Church called wrath. Violence—anger translated into physical action—became a mainstay of entertainment. Tens of millions of Americans played luridly violent video games such as "Grand Theft Auto" and "Call of Duty." The United States had significantly higher homicide rates than other industrialized nations. The United States also had the loosest gun laws and highest levels of gun ownership in the industrialized world, an orientation that grew stronger in the 2000s as activists pressed state legislatures to ease restrictions on openly carrying weapons. The gun-slinging world of Western movies drew closer to current reality. Hollywood films continued to set the national standard for entertainment, one increasingly soaked in blood. Watching films made before the late 1960s seemed like looking into an alternative universe of modesty and restraint. From mainstream movies to horror films, the silver screen poured forth the infliction of pain and destruction. "Bloodletting, sadism and slaughter are now taken for granted," wrote David Thomson, one of the most astute critics of modern film. "In term of the cruelties we no longer notice, we are another species."[44]

Hollywood set standards of entertainment for the world as well as the country, as it had since the 1920s. American films

remained one of the nation's most lucrative and influential exports. Hollywood stars were global celebrities. The explicit violence and sexuality of blockbusters, from *Terminator* and *Lethal Weapon* in the 1980s to *Lord of the Rings* and *Avatar* in the 2000s, splashed on to movie screens on every continent. Even one of the last socialist holdouts caved in. Within a decade after Americans departed from Vietnam in defeat, some Vietnamese were complaining that their revolutionary leaders had instead brought in Soviets who were merely "Americans without dollars." Vietnam's citizens turned out to prefer foreigners with more to offer. The United States and Vietnam reopened diplomatic relations in 1995, and the United States quickly emerged as Vietnam's largest trading partner. By 2007, residents of Ho Chi Minh City flocked to plush new cinemas to see films like *Pirates of the Caribbean* with high-tech soundtracks and all the popcorn and super-size soft drinks they wished to buy.[45]

An enjoyment of violence did not extend to sympathy for those breaking laws. The renewed American individualism rejected liberal criminology and its emphasis on social environments. Individuals were to be held strictly responsible for their actions, through tough drug-sentencing guidelines and stiff mandatory sentences from "three-strikes" laws. The U.S. prison population began to grow sharply in the mid-1970s. Up until then, American incarceration rates had remained stable throughout the twentieth century, and had been in line with the rates in other industrialized nations. Indeed, in the nineteenth century, Europeans had come to the United States to study its penal system. "In no country is criminal justice administered with more mildness," Alexis de Tocqueville wrote after touring American penitentiaries in 1831. After the 1970s, however, Americans lost interest in penitence in those penitentiaries and grew disillusioned with rehabilitation. They wanted punishment for individuals who chose to break the law.[46]

While Europeans continued their more moderate treatment of prisoners, including putting an end to capital punishment, which they tended to view as a medieval atrocity, Americans turned in the opposite direction. The United States put more of

its citizens to death than any countries other than China and Iran. In 2009, it was the only nation in the Western Hemisphere to execute its own citizens, almost half of them in Texas. From 380,000 inmates in 1975, the overall U.S. prison population soared to 2.3 million in 2008, a quarter of them for nonviolent drug offenses. This was the highest total number and the highest incarceration rate of any nation. "We have 5 percent of the world's population and 25 percent of the people in prison," U.S. Senator Jim Webb (D-VA) observed. "Either we're the most evil people on earth, or we're doing something wrong."[47]

Whether or not there was something wrong, the harsh new American prison regime that developed after the mid-1970s was distinctive among industrialized nations. It targeted juveniles as well. The United States was one of a small handful of countries that gave life-without-parole sentences to some people who committed crimes before the age of eighteen. In 2005, the other such countries combined for a total of twelve such sentences. The United States had 2,200, including more than 350 for people whose crimes had been committed when they were fifteen or younger. Prison sentences in general in the United States were significantly longer on average than elsewhere. And lengthy sentences and mass incarceration added to class and racial inequalities, due to the 30–40 percent average reduction in a person's annual earnings that a prison record caused. These policies also indirectly helped increase inequality through the disenfranchisement of felons and ex-felons (disproportionately black and likely Democratic voters), a tipping factor of a few percentage points in the close elections of recent history. A study in 2007 demonstrated three specific impacts of these disenfranchisements of voters: George W. Bush would not have been awarded Florida's crucial electoral votes in the protracted 2000 presidential contest, sending Al Gore to the White House instead; seven modern Republican senators would not have won their initial elections; and the tax cuts of 2001 and 2003 that shifted wealth upward would have been much more difficult to enact. American prison policies across three decades revealed a culture comfortable with incarceration and its costs, emphatic

about people being free to do what they chose and to pay for the consequences when they chose wrong.[48]

Inequality Rising

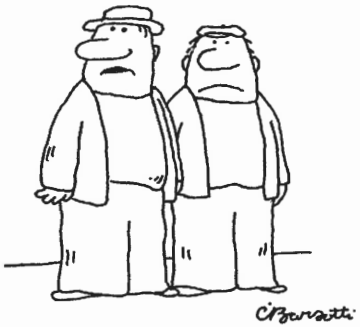
The single most significant result of the victory of market values in U.S. public policy since the 1970s was a steady rise in economic inequality. The gap between rich and poor grew wider, startlingly so at times, and the bulk of the vaunted American middle class saw its economic security begin to slip away. This process was not always obvious, masked by several concurrent developments. First, globalized manufacturing and trade patterns kept downward pressure on prices of consumer goods, from milk to toys to airline tickets to computers. A larger market meant more competition in many sectors of the economy. Imports from low-wage countries like China and Mexico stayed relatively inexpensive. Second, the credit industry expanded its reach dramatically. Americans built up impressive debt loads on credit cards, supplementing their home mortgages and car loans. They bought what they could not formerly afford and preserved an outward appearance of economic good health. Average household debt grew by 80 percent between 1990 and 2005. Third, a traditional cultural style of social egalitarianism restrained some demonstrations of material excess by wealthy citizens. Just as working-class kids dressed in middle-class styles, so did many elite kids. Fitting in remained a goal in a society where most people claimed to be "middle class." Flaunting of wealth was common enough, from mansions and yachts to jewelry and cars, but social pressure to conform provided a measure of balance to the public behavior of at least some elites.[49]

Regardless of such constraints, however, the distance between the richest and poorest Americans, measured in simple dollars and cents, grew vast from the 1970s on. The widely shared income gains of the decades from 1946 to 1976 disappeared, replaced by dramatic increases for those citizens at the top. Between 1979 and 2007, the share of national income going

to the richest 1 percent of families grew from 9 percent to 24 percent (an increase of 150 percent in one generation), the largest share for them since 1928. In the same years, the share of national income accruing to the poorest 90 percent of families dropped from 66 percent to 50 percent. According to the U.S. Census Bureau, in 2009 the gap between the richest and poorest Americans reached its widest amount on record. The shift during the later years and further up the chain was even more dramatic. Between 1992 and 2007, the bottom 90 percent of Americans watched their real incomes rise by 13 percent, compared with an increase of 399 percent for the top four hundred individuals. Between 2002 and 2007, the top 1 percent of households doubled their share of the total national income. By 2010, the top 0.1 percent of Americans—fewer than a third of a million people—were earning as much as the bottom 120 million of their fellow citizens. "At the same time that the rich have been pulling away from the middle class," observed financial columnist James Surowiecki, "the very rich have been pulling away from the pretty rich, and the very, very rich have been pulling away from the very rich."[50]

The increasingly information-driven U.S. economy placed a premium on education. While college graduates and those with advanced degrees saw their real income increase by a quarter in these decades, workers with high school diplomas felt a drop of 2 percent, and high school dropouts experienced a remarkable 18 percent decrease. Political leaders, particularly Republicans, took no action to mitigate this trend toward inequality. Instead, they cut federal taxes in 2001 and 2003 in a manner that gave 62 percent of the benefits to the wealthiest 20 percent of Americans by 2010, and they allowed the federal minimum wage in 2006 to reach its lowest inflation-adjusted value since the 1940s.[51]

Many factors contributed to this widening gap. Lower numbers of unionized workers, high divorce rates, and elevated incarceration rates all depressed family incomes. Quick to shift production sites in a more globalized economy, corporations were able to keep wages lower even when worker productivity picked back up after its 1973–79 lull, thus boosting company



"There, there it is again—the invisible hand of the marketplace giving us the finger."

FIGURE 6.1.
American workers were not sure that the pro-market reforms of the 1970s would benefit them. Indeed, the next three decades saw a dramatic shift of shares of national income and wealth moving up the socioeconomic scale to more affluent Americans. Courtesy Charles Barsotti/*The New Yorker*.

profits. Employee benefits like retirement plans and health insurance coverage also shrank dramatically as a result of corporate cost-cutting, reducing security even for workers still on the job. Not surprisingly, poverty rates in the United States, which had dropped by half between 1959 and 1973, began rising again, reaching 15 percent in 1994 and remaining at 13 percent in 2008 (or higher, using unofficial rates). The rate was 18 percent for minors; nearly one in five American children were growing up in poverty in the new millennium. Most other industrialized nations experienced similar trends after the 1970s, but only the United Kingdom came close to matching the sharp increase in economic inequality in the United States. The United States had the most uneven distribution of wealth of any industrialized nation.[52]

"What I want to see above all," President Reagan declared in a speech in 1983, "is that this remains a country where someone

can always get rich." Income statistics made it clear that Reagan's wish remained fulfilled a generation later. Indeed, wealth, a person's accumulated and inherited assets, provided a clearer indicator of one's real economic condition than income, a person's intake of money in a given year. Wealth was more unequally distributed than income. In 2007, the top 1 percent of American households owned 34.5 percent of the nation's wealth. The next 19 percent of households owned 50.5 percent of the wealth. So the bottom 80 percent—four out of five citizens—shared just 15 percent of the nation's private assets. This kind of skewing of the distribution of wealth was similar to the distribution in the poorest nations, though of course those countries had less total wealth to skew. The maldistribution of wealth shaped American society in a myriad of ways, from the wildly unequal endowments of the top two dozen universities compared to those of the next several hundred, to the opening of still more exclusive downhill ski resorts such as Beaver Creek, Colorado, and Deer Valley, Utah, to the multimillion-dollar cost of winning election to the U.S. Senate, to the proliferation of gated residential communities and luxury yachts. Even the *Wall Street Journal*, the nation's leading mouthpiece for the virtues of entrepreneurial capitalism, acknowledged in 2005 "a widening rich-poor gap" and admitted that "the level of [socioeconomic] mobility in the U.S. has been stuck over the past three decades, and some studies suggest mobility in continental Europe is higher." The future of the land of opportunity was unclear.[53]

In 1896, Merrill Gates, a distinguished educator and president of Amherst College, addressed the question of how to assimilate Native Americans more fully into mainstream American society. Capitalist values were crucial. "To bring him out of savagery into citizenship we must make the Indian more intelligently selfish," Gates wrote. "We need to *awaken in him wants*" that would create "an Indian wearing trousers with a pocket in them, and with a *pocket that aches to be filled with dollars*." Such awakened wants and aching pockets were in plentiful supply in the later era after the 1970s. Young and old Americans alike,

according to surveys, placed a premium value on "being very well off financially." The "small is beautiful" movement of the late 1960s and early 1970s ultimately succumbed, among the vast majority of citizens, to the "bigger is better" movement of sport utility vehicles, larger houses, super-sized restaurant portions, and broader waistlines—a truly expanding America. To compete for student applicants, universities by the new millennium began to build luxurious facilities, from cosmopolitan dining services to spa-style recreation emporiums. The average American increased the amount of garbage thrown out each day by more than 50 percent between 1975 and 2005. More than three-quarters of respondents told pollsters in 2005 that "Americans overconsume," but when asked the follow-up question, "Do you think we should change that?" the majority agreed, "No, it's one of the great things about being American." In the late 1970s, President Carter called for common sacrifice to meet a national crisis of energy; after the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001, President Bush asked for no sacrifice at all by average voters. "Get down to Disney World in Florida," he told citizens, urging them to restore confidence in air travel and the U.S. economy by flying and shopping. "Take your families and enjoy life the way we want it to be enjoyed." The words "common" and "sacrifice" rarely appeared together any longer in the national lexicon.[54]

Instead, Americans by the early 2000s spoke a more distilled version of their traditional language of individualism. They lived in bigger houses, on average, with smaller families, farther out in expanding suburbs. More than most peoples, Americans moved to new places for jobs and often lived far from extended family. Their nuclear families unraveled frequently, nearly half of marriages ending in divorce. Individuals in a culture that celebrated individual fulfillment, they found the inevitable sacrifices of married life difficult to reconcile with their own happiness. They had fewer children, and many more of those grew up with only one parent. Forty percent of all births were to unmarried women, a figure more than twice as large as in 1980. Americans valued privacy, or at least personal space. Ninety percent

drove to work, the vast majority of them alone. Fewer than 5 percent used public transportation to get to their jobs. They seemed to appreciate the autonomy of their cars and being free of other people in close proximity. The same was true with Americans' primary forms of entertainment, televisions and computers, used mostly in isolation. "Technology has privatized our leisure time," Harvard political scientist Robert Putnam observed. "The distinctive effect of technology has been to enable us to get entertainment and information while remaining entirely alone." Americans remained famously friendly, according to foreign visitors, but the institutions and habits of contemporary American society pulled them increasingly apart from each other.[55]

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Chapter 6. More and Less Equal since the 1970s

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